

ASSYRIAN EMPIRE



THE GRAND CITY OF ASHUR, beside the Tigris river in northern Mesopotamia (present-day Iraq), developed as an important trading centre; by 2000 BC, it had become the capital of a great Assyrian kingdom. From 1400 BC, Assyrian armies were marching north and west to secure trade and obtain booty and tribute. Feared for their military strength, they soon came to dominate the Near East. Assyrian kings built several capital cities after Ashur, of which Nimrud and Nineveh were the most magnificent. Assyrian civilization and culture, however, were heavily influenced by Babylonia to the south, and it was the Babylonians who eventually absorbed the Assyrians into their empire.



Extent of the empire

The greatest extent of the empire was reached in the 7th century, when the well-equipped soldiers of King Ashurbanipal conquered and held lands from Egypt to Iran. Assyrian governors controlled the provinces. They were expected to send taxes back to the Assyrian capital and recruit soldiers for the army.



Bronze armour

Army

The Assyrian army was the most efficient fighting machine of its time, and its reputation alone was often enough to frighten rebellious states into surrender. At first, the army consisted of native Assyrians, but Tiglath-Pileser III (745–727 BC) recruited men from other areas of the empire. They were armed with iron helmets, armour, spears, swords, and shields. The Assyrians also used chariots and siege engines (battering rams on wheels), the most advanced weapons of the time.



Assyrian official

King Ashurnasirpal II (r.883–859 BC)

Siege engine

Stone relief of Assyrians attacking a town on the Euphrates river

Nimrud and Nineveh

By 900 BC, the city of Ashur was overcrowded. Nimrud was built in the 9th century BC; Nineveh was constructed in the 7th century BC. These cities were famous for their splendid palaces and temples.

Exotic animals from all over the empire, such as elephants and lions, filled the wildlife parks and gardens that surrounded the city of Nineveh.



Politics

At his coronation, the Assyrian king swore to expand the empire. The Assyrians believed their god Ashur (after whom the first city was named) chose each king, so he had absolute power. He appointed all the governors of the various parts of his empire, led the army, and was responsible for all the temples. The king demonstrated his power and wealth by many ambitious building projects. A network of spies reported to the king on all matters within the empire.



Gold earrings

Precious stones

Queens of Assyria

Some Assyrian queens were so powerful they became legendary. One such, Samsuramat (Semiramis), dominated court for 42 years in the 9th century BC. Some royal jewellery has been found in tombs at Nimrud.

Art and literature

Brightly painted, stone-relief carvings, the most spectacular of all Assyrian art forms, decorated palace walls from 900 BC. Artists decorated royal furniture with carvings of real or mythical animals, such as sphinxes.



Ivory winged sphinx

Timeline

2400 BC The city of Ashur dominates trade routes.

1900 BC Assyrians establish trading colonies in Anatolia (modern Turkey).

1250 BC Kings of Assyria campaign as far as the Mediterranean and Babylon.

879 BC Ashurnasirpal II builds a new capital at Kalhu (Nimrud).

744–727 BC King Tiglath-Pileser III creates an empire.

721–705 BC Sargon II builds capital at Khorsabad (Dur-Sharrukin).



Gold earring

701 BC Sennacherib leads his army to Jerusalem from his new capital at Nineveh.

689 BC Sennacherib destroys Babylon.

664 BC Ashurbanipal attacks and conquers Egypt.

612 BC Median and Babylonian armies destroy Nineveh.

609 BC Crown prince Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon finally defeats the Assyrians.

606 BC The Medes from Iran sack Nineveh.

Sennacherib

Sennacherib (r.704–681 BC), a strong king, spent many years building Nineveh. He established control over the coast of the Mediterranean, and destroyed Babylon, but he was murdered by his jealous sons.

